

Public space mapping

What this tool produces · *A comprehensive visual inventory detailing the geographical distribution of urban amenities, pedestrian paths, and formal/informal human activities within a defined radius.*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Dimensions

Spatial

Social / User

Preparing the workshop · *Public space mapping*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Why this tool matters

Refusing to view the street from a distant helicopter; stepping down to the pavement to painstakingly trace the daily footsteps, struggles, and informal habits of the residents.

Evidence we produce

A comprehensive visual inventory detailing the geographical distribution of urban amenities, pedestrian paths, and formal/informal human activities within a defined radius.

Duration & Material

Duration · 1 to 2 weeks of field observation and mapping

Material · Printed base maps, standardized coding legends, GPS-enabled smartphones, colored markers

Reference case

UN-Habitat's Public space site-specific assessment utilizes this incremental mapping methodology to gather granular data on accessibility and user dynamics. In places like Sharjah (UAE), young participants used these mapping tools to express their ideas on how to upgrade local public spaces, directly translating field observations into actionable design criteria.

Suggested agenda · Brief (10 min) > Method walk-through (15 min) > Animation canvas (60-90 min) > Harvest (20 min)

Public space typologies × quality

Duration
1 to 2 weeks of field observation and mapping

Squares & plazas civic, ceremonial	Parks & gardens green, restorative	Streetscape corridor, conviviality
Riverbanks / waterfronts edge condition	Pocket spaces micro pauses	Markets & precincts commerce, encounter

For each space · rate quality, surface gaps, prioritize tactical works.

Harvesting our *learnings*

After running the canvas, capture three layers of insight.

What inspires me

Stand-out signals, surprising stories, ideas to remember

How to apply it here

Concrete adaptations to our context, our team, our constraints

What we need to be autonomous

Skills, allies, resources, decisions still to secure

Each participant fills a copy. Then debrief together to surface patterns and next steps.